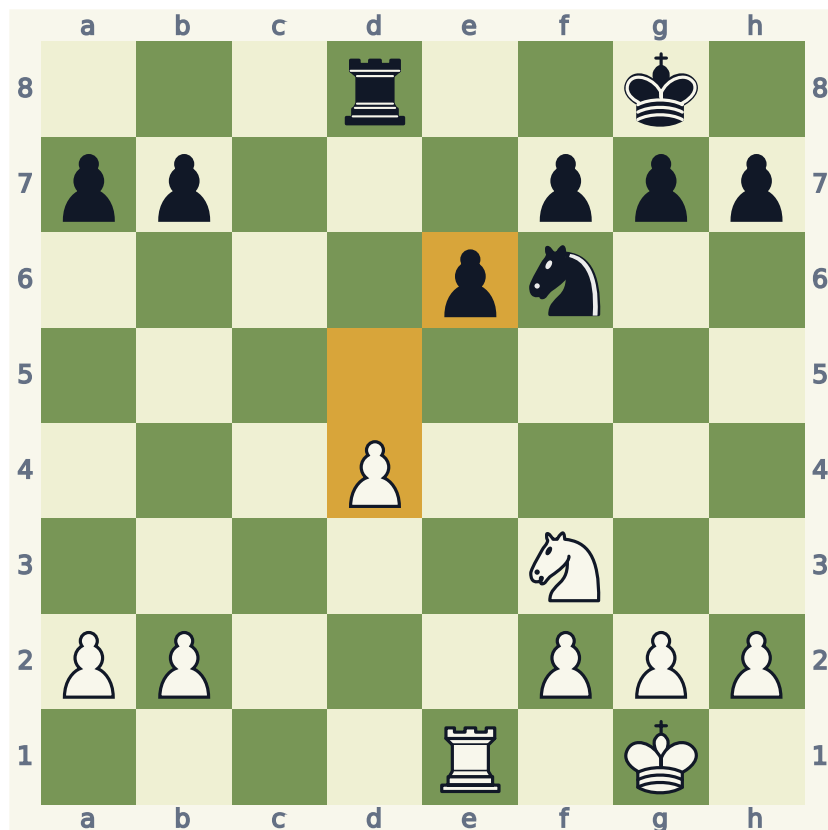


The isolated queen pawn

Activity now versus a possible target later.

An isolated queen pawn, often on d4 or d5, has no friendly c- or e-pawn neighbor. Its owner may gain space, active pieces and open adjacent files. The opponent seeks a blockade, exchanges and pressure. The central advance is a key resource: an isolated pawn is not merely something to defend.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- White's d4-pawn is isolated.
- The e-file is semi-open for White against e6.
- d5 can exchange the isolated pawn and clear the e-file.

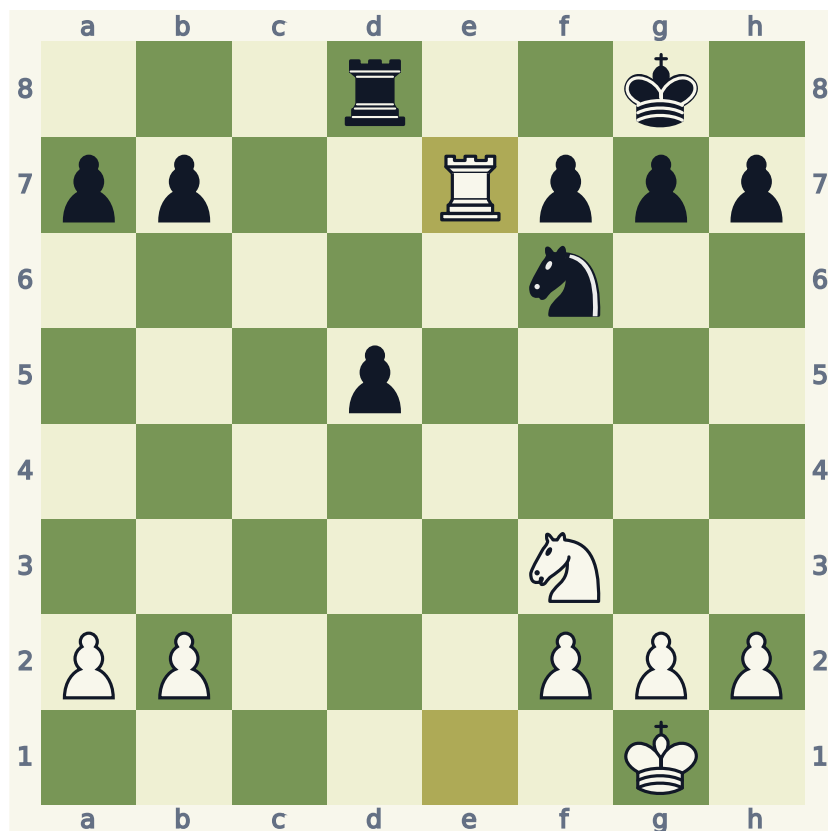
REMEMBER

- Owner: seek active pieces and a timely advance.
- Defender: blockade, then increase pressure.
- Evaluate each exchange by its effect on activity.

Follow the logic

1. d5 exd5 2. Re7

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



d5

Offer to transform the structure. Before advancing an isolated pawn, inspect captures and the activity you obtain afterward.

...exd5

Black captures it. White is now a pawn down, but the e6-pawn no longer blocks the e-file.

Re7

The rook penetrates and attacks b7 and f7 along a clear seventh rank. This demonstrates activity for a pawn, not a proven winning sacrifice.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black can seek to blockade d5 before White advances, and should consider whether accepting the pawn gives White too much rook activity. White must compare the sacrifice with quieter support of d4.

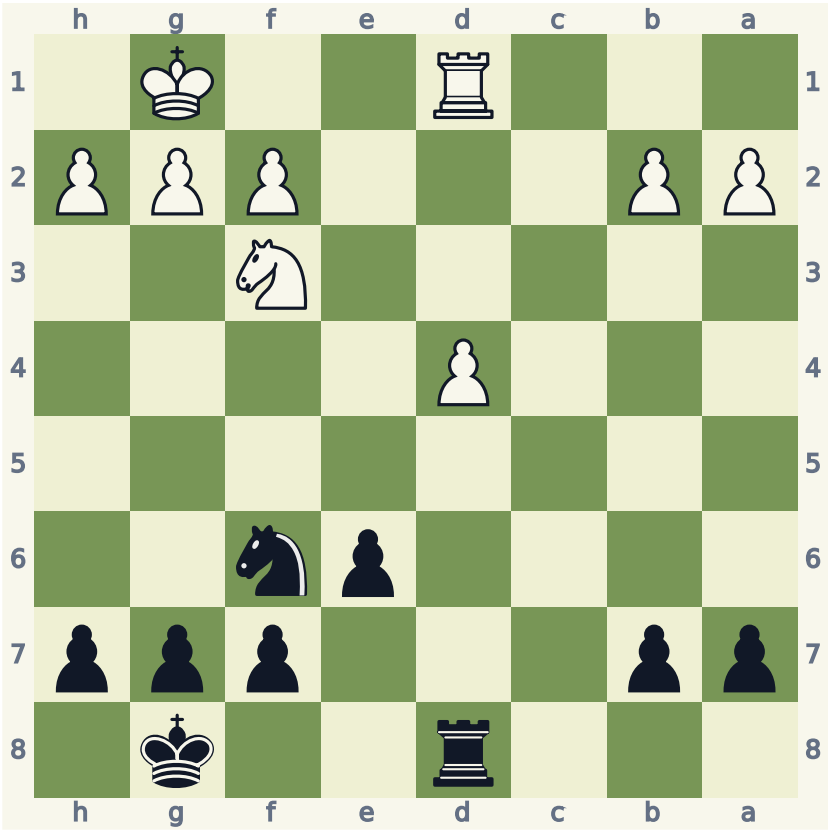
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not automatically sacrifice the isolated pawn because a file opens. Count concrete threats, Black's defensive resources and whether the activity survives exchanges. This line illustrates the tradeoff without asserting an engine verdict.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | BLACK TO MOVE



- 1. Where should Black place a blockading knight?
- 2. Why is a knight on d5 difficult to drive away by a white pawn?
- 3. What does White's Ne5 try to preserve?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If all minor pieces were exchanged, would the isolated pawn automatically be lost?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 3r2k1/pp3ppp/4pn2/8/3P4/5N2/PP3PPP/3R2K1 b - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. ...Nd5 puts a knight directly in front of d4. It blocks the pawn's advance and is supported by e6. Black can later add pressure to d4 rather than rush to capture it.
2. White has no c- or e-pawn to attack d5. White may need to exchange the knight with a piece, create kingside activity or change the structure by another means.
3. Ne5 uses the isolated pawn's support and keeps pieces active. The knight can create threats around f7 and c6. The owner of the isolated pawn usually needs active tasks, especially before simplifying into an ending.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1... Nd5 2. Ne5

Changed feature: No. Rook activity, king position and the possibility of advancing or exchanging the pawn still matter. The target is more likely to be relevant, but must actually be attacked.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Play the exercise from each side. Black tries to maintain Nd5; White tries to exchange it or generate a useful threat before further trades.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 05, 10, 19. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.